

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

QA Skills Matrix

Map your team's real capability across twelve competencies, expose gaps and spot key-person risk before it bites.

Purpose

A skills matrix turns vague impressions ("Dan does the automation, Sofia is our strongest tester") into an evidence base you can act on. It plots each engineer against a defined set of competencies using a shared proficiency scale, so you can see where the team is deep, where it is thin, and where a single person is carrying a capability on their own.

Used well, it drives three decisions: what to hire for, what to develop, and where to reduce key-person risk.

When to use it

- In your first 90 days leading a team, to replace hearsay with a baseline.
- Before writing a job description — so you hire for the gap, not for a clone of who you already have.
- At planning time, to decide which work only one person can currently do.
- Ahead of development conversations, to ground each person's growth plan in evidence.
- Twice a year as a living document — not a one-off audit that rots in a drawer.

Instructions

1. Agree the competencies that matter for your context. Twelve is a sensible ceiling; more becomes noise.
2. Adopt the behaviourally-anchored 0-4 scale below so a "3" means the same thing for everyone.
3. Rate on observed behaviour, not job titles or how long someone has been testing.
4. Have each engineer self-assess first, then calibrate together. The conversation about the gap between the two scores is often more useful than either number.
5. Roll the ratings up into a gap analysis and a key-person-risk check.
6. Share it openly with the team. A secret matrix breeds suspicion; a shared one drives development.

Proficiency scale (behaviourally anchored, 0-4)

Level	Label	What it looks like in practice
0	None	No exposure. Cannot yet contribute in this area.

Level	Label	What it looks like in practice
1	Awareness	Can describe the concept and why it matters; needs close guidance to do it. Follows a runbook someone else wrote.
2	Working	Handles routine cases independently; asks for help on the harder ones. Reliable on the day-to-day.
3	Proficient	Handles complex, ambiguous cases independently. Sets the local standard and reviews others' work in this area.
4	Expert	Defines the approach for the whole org, is the person others are sent to, and actively grows this capability in others.

Worked example

Northstar Digital's inherited team of six, rated across twelve competencies. Ratings are the lead's calibrated assessment, not the engineers' self-scores.

Competency	Sofia	Dan	Ravi	Grace	Hassan	Emma	Team high
Exploratory testing	4	2	3	3	3	1	4
Test design techniques	3	2	3	2	2	1	3
UI automation	1	3	1	2	1	1	3
API / contract testing	2	2	2	1	2	1	2
Performance testing	1	1	0	1	1	0	1
Security awareness	2	1	2	1	1	1	2
Accessibility	1	0	1	2	1	1	2
Domain knowledge (payments/finance)	3	2	4	2	2	1	4
Defect analysis & reporting	3	2	3	2	2	1	3
CI/CD & pipelines	1	3	1	1	1	0	3
Stakeholder communication	3	1	2	2	2	1	3
Mentoring & coaching	3	1	2	1	1	0	3

Gap analysis

Competency	Team high	Read	Priority
Performance testing	1	Nobody past Awareness. A genuine capability hole, and the B2B API is being sold against SLAs.	High
Accessibility	2	Only Grace at Working; no depth. Legal and reputational exposure.	Medium
CI/CD & pipelines	3	One person (Dan) only. The team cannot maintain or improve the pipeline without him.	High

Competency	Team high	Read	Priority
UI automation	3	One person (Dan) at Proficient; everyone else at Awareness/Working. The flaky suite has a single owner.	High
API / contract testing	2	Broad but shallow — nobody at Proficient, despite a public API sold to partners.	Medium
Mentoring & coaching	3	Concentrated in Sofia. Limits how fast the team can grow itself.	Medium

Key-person risk

- Dan is the single point of failure for both UI automation and CI/CD (the only "3" in each). If he leaves — and he is quietly burning out — two capabilities collapse to Awareness overnight. This is the sharpest risk on the board.
- Ravi is the only deep source of payments/finance domain knowledge (the only "4"). For a company whose legacy billing monolith is fragile, that is concentrated risk.
- Sofia carries mentoring, stakeholder communication and exploratory leadership. She is also the informal lead — a lot of the team's resilience runs through one person.

How to interpret the results

- Read down the columns for people (who is stretched, who is one-dimensional) and across the rows for capability (where the team is deep or exposed).
- A row where the team high is 0-1 is a hiring or training decision, not a rota decision — no amount of reshuffling creates a skill nobody has.
- A capability held by exactly one person at level 3-4 is key-person risk, regardless of how good that person is. Treat "we're fine, Dan handles it" as a warning, not reassurance.
- Do not chase a matrix of all 4s. A healthy team is deliberately shaped — deep where risk is high, adequate elsewhere. Aim for at least two people at Working-or-above on every business-critical capability (the "bus factor of two" rule).

Blank reusable version

Competency	Person 1	Person 2	Person 3	Person 4	Team high	Gap? (Y/N)
Exploratory testing						
Test design techniques						
UI automation						
API / contract testing						
Performance testing						
Security awareness						
Accessibility						
Domain knowledge						
Defect analysis & reporting						

Competency	Person 1	Person 2	Person 3	Person 4	Team high	Gap? (Y/N)
CI/CD & pipelines						
Stakeholder communication						
Mentoring & coaching						

Scoring key: 0 None · 1 Awareness · 2 Working · 3 Proficient · 4 Expert. Add a "Key-person risk" note for any capability held by a single person at level 3–4.

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Rating on job title or tenure instead of observed behaviour. Scoring everyone generously to avoid awkward conversations, which hides the very gaps the tool exists to find. Treating the matrix as a performance ranking rather than a capability map — it is about the team's shape, not who is "best". Building it once and never revisiting it. And celebrating a single brilliant specialist while ignoring that they are a single point of failure.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

The most valuable cell in the matrix is rarely the lowest score — it is the capability held by exactly one person. Fix your key-person risks before you chase your skill gaps: a gap slows you down, but a bus factor of one can stop you dead.